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Introduction

There are millions of chemical compounds existing in nature with different compositions and properties, formed from less than 100 naturally occurring elements.

The discovery of elements is linked with human civilization. In stone age man has used some metals to suit his needs without knowing that they are elements. Soon he learnt to extract elements from ores and fashion them into his daily life. Over the years, more and more elements were discovered. In 1789, Lavoisier from France, published the first list of chemical elements containing 23 elements after several experimental investigations.

Antoine Lavoisier classified the substances into four groups of elements namely acid-making elements, gas-like elements, metallic elements and earthy elements

Table 3.1 Lavoisier table

acid-making elements	gas-like elements
sulphur	light
phosphorus	caloric (heat)
charcoal (carbon)	oxygen
	azote (nitrogen)
	hydrogen

metallic elements	earthy elements
cobalt, mercury, tin	lime (calcium oxide)
copper, nickel, iron	magnesia (magnesium oxide)
gold, lead, silver, zinc	barytes (barium sulphate)
manganese, tungten	argilla (aluminium oxide)
platina (platinum)	silex (silicon dioxide)

3.1 Classification of Elements

During the 19th century, scientists have isolated several elements and the list of known elements increased. Currently, we have 118 known elements. Out of 118 elements, 92 elements with atomic numbers 1 to 92 are found in nature. Scientists have found out there are some similarities in properties among certain elements. This observation has led to the idea of classification of elements based on their properties. In fact, classification will be beneficial for the effective utilization of these elements. Several attempts were made to classify the elements. However, classification based on the atomic weights led to the construction of a proper form of periodic table.

In 1817, J. W. Döbereiner classified some elements such as chlorine, bromine and iodine with similar chemical properties into the group of three elements called as triads. In triads, the atomic weight of the middle element nearly equal to the arithmetic mean of the atomic weights of the remaining two elements. However, only a limited number of elements can be grouped as triads.